



Security Watch

Multiple Internet Explorer Vulnerabilities

The Problem

In April, multiple vulnerabilities were reported in Internet Explorer. These can be exploited by the evil folks to conduct "cross-site scripting attacks," phishing attacks, or compromise your system.

For example, a certain error can be exploited to corrupt memory in a way that may allow execution of arbitrary code on your computer. Then, a certain unspecified error can be exploited to spoof information displayed in the address bar. In fact, according to Secunia.com, there are *ten* vulnerabilities!

Microsoft has released patches for IE 5 and 6, and has rated them as "critical." While Windows users with the Automatic Update function enabled will have the fixes delivered to them automatically, Microsoft recommends that customers without Automatic Update turned on should "immediately" go to their Web site and download the fixes.

The Solution

You need to patch Internet Explorer immediately. Head to www.microsoft.com/windows/ie/downloads/critical/default.mspx for details and for the download link. The most critical sub-patch in this mega-patch is the one that fixes the recently-disclosed DHTML Method Call Memory Corruption Vulnerability, which affects all recent versions of Windows—including, of course, 98 and XP.

the kernel were pure GPL in its licence terms... you couldn't link proprietary video drivers into it, whether dynamically or statically," FSF attorney Eben Moglen said in a January interview.

Here's a scenario where open source supporters are clearly shooting themselves in the foot!

MY IDEA, YOUR PATENT

Patent Those Light Bulb Moments... Or Else

Here's one of the few non-success stories that make it to the news. Geoff Goodfellow could have been \$600 million (Rs 2,700 crore) richer, it turns out, after a company called NTP got that amount for having invented something—which Goodfellow had done several years earlier.

Back in 1982, Geoff came up with a revolutionary idea: sending messages to portable devices using wireless technology! "What's so great about that?", all of us with GPRS, cell phones and PDAs will ask. We draw your attention to the date—1982!

Although he did get financial help for a venture in the early '90s from some companies such as Motorola, his venture flopped. This is no surprise, because back then all we

had were alphanumeric pagers, and most of the portable devices we take for granted today hadn't even been invented!

So Goodfellow did what any jaded silicon valley professional would do: went to Prague, bought a bar and gave up on his idea of wireless e-mail.

Of course, while he was there, serving liquor to cheery patrons, a new device called the BlackBerry was released, which, as we all know now, offers a wireless e-mail feature. Goodfellow thought the world had forgotten that it was his idea in the first place, but didn't count on the thoroughness of a lawyer defending a patent claim in a multi-million dollar lawsuit!

Turns out James H Wallace Jr, the lawyer in question, was defending a company called NTP's patent rights to, yes, you guessed it, "wireless e-mail." That's when thorough research led him to discover that it was actually Goodfellow who invented wireless e-mail.



Geoff Goodfellow—Picture Courtesy NYTimes.com

HOT

Portable Video



MP3 players—hard disk or Flash—with colour widescreens capable of playing movies, displaying digicam images, and playing songs in various formats are in! You can get these for just a few thousand more than plain MP3 players.

Plain Audio

NOT



Ordinary MP3 players with a three or four-colour display, or worse, a greyscale display. Or, MP3 players that have support for just voice recording, with a capacity of 256 MB to 512 MB. Spend a few grand more and get yourself a video-capable player!

Goodfellow happens to be one of the small group of people who, like open source proponents, does not believe in patenting ideas or software.

Almost a decade after Goodfellow envisaged the wireless e-mail concept, Thomas J. Campana Jr., who later went on to be one of the founders of NTP, patented wireless e-mail.



One Silly Question

"What would you do if Google went down?"



"It would be the end of my PG project!"
Ankita, Lucknow



"I will sell my laptop!!"
Tanmay Bhargava, Delhi



"I shall finally sleep"
Vishal Nagota, Jaipur



"I will buy Google and rebuild it!!"
Prashant Tiwari, Shikowabad



"I will build a company like Google"
Alok Jha, Ranchi